Seeing Through Photographs ✕

Today's goal • 3/3 items

Module 1
Introduction to Seeing Through Photographs

Module 2
One Subject, Many Perspectives

Part I: Introduction
- ✓ Introduction to Module 2
  Reading • 2 min
- ✓ Artistic Equivalents
  Reading • 2 min
- ✓ Vik Muniz on Photographing the Familiar
  Video • 3 min

Part II: Telescopes and Cameras
- ✓ Introduction to Part II: Surface, Scale, and Technology
  Video • 2 min
- ✓ Practical Scenario
  Real-world application • 5 min
- ✓ Moons and Surfaces
  Reading • 5 min
- ✓ Hear More: Sarah Meister on Eugène Atget. Pendant l'éclipse. 1912
  Video • 3 min
- ✓ Hear More: Liz Deschenes on Tilt/Swing (360° field of vision, version 1), 2009
  Video • 1 min
- ✓ Surface, Scale, Technology
  Dialogue • 15 min

Part III: Seeing the Unseen
- ✓ Introduction to Part III: Man on the Moon
  Video • 2 min
- ✓ Photographs by NASA
  Reading • 2 min
- ✓ Hear More: Sarah Meister on U.S.G.S. and NASA. Surveyor III. Surface of the Moon, Day 319, W-F. 1967
  Video • 1 min
- ✓ Practical Scenario
  Real-world application • 5 min
- ✓ Who Does the Moon Belong To?
  Reading • 4 min

Part IV: It's Only a Paper Moon
- ✓ Introduction to Part IV: Vernacular and Fine Art Photographs of the Moon
  Video • 3 min
- ✓ Moon Phases
  Reading • 6 min
- ✓ Hear More: Sarah Meister on Ansel Adams. Moonrise, Hernandez, New Mexico. 1941
  Video • 3 min
- ✓ Man on the Moon and Paper Moons
  Dialogue • 15 min

Part V: Review and Respond
- ✓ Optional Readings and Resources
  Reading • 10 min
- ✓ Practice Memory Check
  Practice Assignment • Grade: 100%
- ✓ Optional Discussion Prompts and Creative Challenges
  Reading • 10 min

Module 3
Documents and the Documentary

Part I: Introduction
- ✓ Introduction to Module 3
  Reading • 2 min
- ✓ Sarah Meister on Documents and the Documentary
  Video • 3 min

Part II: Framing Reality
- ✓ Facts and Fictions
  Reading • 6 min
- ✓ Fictions and Facts
  Reading • 6 min
- ✓ Practical Scenario
  Real-world application • 5 min
- ✓ Hear More: Mike Mandel on Evidence, 1977
  Video • 4 min
- ✓ Hear More: Thomas Demand on Room (Zimmer), 1996
  Video • 1 min

Part III: Words and Pictures
- ✓ Artist Spotlight: Dorothea Lange
  Reading • 4 min
- ✓ Practical Scenario
  Real-world application • 5 min
- ✓ Hear More: Sarah Meister on Dorothea Lange. Migrant Mother. 1936
  Video • 2 min
- ✓ Hear More: Sarah Meister on Dorothea Lange. On the Road to Los Angeles, California. March 1937
  Video • 1 min
- ✓ Artist Spotlight: Gordon Parks
  Reading • 4 min

Part IV: Focus on New Documents, 1967
- ✓ Introduction to Part IV: Sarah Meister on New Documents
  Video • 3 min
- ✓ New Documents: Arbus, Friedlander, and Winogrand
  Reading • 4 min

Part V: Review and Respond
- ✓ Practice Memory Check
  Practice Assignment • Grade: 100%
- ✓ Optional Discussion Prompts and Creative Challenges
  Reading • 10 min
- ✓ Optional Readings and Resources
  Reading • 10 min

Module 4
One and Another

Part I: Introduction
- ✓ Introduction to Module 4
  Reading • 2 min
- ✓ Sarah Meister on Photography and Multiplicity
  Video • 2 min

Part II: Albums and Books
- ✓ Artwork Spotlight: Frances Benjamin Johnston's The Hampton Album, 1899-1900
  Reading • 2 min
- ✓ Hear More: Sarah Meister on Frances Benjamin Johnston. The Hampton Album. 1899-1900
  Video • 1 min
- ✓ Practical Scenario
  Real-world application • 5 min
- ○ **Photo Books**
  Reading • 8 min

Part III: Bodies of Work
- ○ Photo Series
  Reading • 13 min
- ○ Hear More: Nicholas Nixon on The Brown Sisters, 1975–2022
  Video • 1 min
- ○ Practical Scenario
  Real-world application • 5 min
- ○ Hear More: Sohrab Hura on Snow, 2015–ongoing
  Video • 5 min

Part IV: One from Many
- ○ One from Many
  Reading • 8 min
- ○ Hear More: Irina Rozovsky on Miracle Center, 2019–ongoing
  Video • 5 min

Part V: Review and Respond
- ○ Practice Memory Check
  Practice Assignment • 30 min
- ○ Optional Discussion Prompts and Creative Challenges
  Reading • 10 min
- ○ Optional Readings and Resources
  Reading • 10 min
- ○ Optional Mid-Course Survey
  Reading • 5 min

Module 5
Constructing Narratives, Challenging Histories

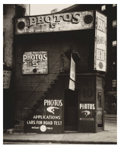
Module 6
Pictures of People

Module 7
Ocean of Images

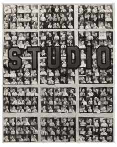
Photo Books

0:22 / 7:10 1x

Walker Evans



Walker Evans. *License Photo Studio, New York*. 1934. Gelatin silver print, 9 15/16 × 7 15/16" (25.3 × 20.2 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. The Ben Schultz Memorial Collection, gift of the photographer. © 2020 Walker Evans Archive, The Metropolitan Museum of Art

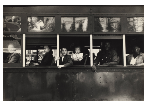


Walker Evans. *Penny Picture Display, Savannah*. 1936. Gelatin silver print, 8 5/8 × 6 15/16" (21.9 × 17.6 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Gift of Willard Van Dyke. © 2020 Walker Evans Archive, The Metropolitan Museum of Art

In 1938, The Museum of Modern Art published Walker Evans' *American Photographs*, a book that established the creative potential of a sequence of images linked neither by narrative, nor chronology, nor subject. The book features Evans's direct, descriptive photographs from the preceding decade, and through them indirectly offers a picture of America that was as unexpected as it has been enduring. Arts impresario (and Evans's friend) Lincoln Kirstein asked in his afterword for the book: "After looking at these pictures with all their clear, hideous and beautiful detail, their open insanity and pitiful grandeur, compare this vision of a continent as it is, not as it might be or as it was, with any other coherent vision that we have had since the war. What poet has said as much? What painter has shown as much? Only newspapers, the writers of popular music, the technicians of advertising and radio have in their blind energy accidentally, fortuitously, evoked for future historians such a powerful monument to our moment."

Evans attended to the American obsession with photographs, and to the overlooked elements of our local, popular culture expressed through architecture, advertisements, and amusements. But he did not name these as such, and instead placed each picture, without titles or dates, on the right-hand side of each spread, and referenced each in a list at the end of the book's two sections.

Robert Frank



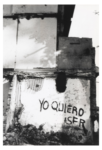
Robert Frank. *Trolley–New Orleans*. 1955. Gelatin silver print, 9 1/16 × 13 3/8" (23.1 × 34 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. The Fellow of Photography Fund, The Family of Man Fund, and Horace W. Goldsmith Fund through Robert B. Menschel. © 2020 Robert Frank

Robert Frank. *Los Angeles*. 1955–56. Gelatin silver print, 12 15/16 x 8 1/2" (32.8 x 21.6 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Purchase. © 2020 Robert Frank

From 1955 to 1957, Robert Frank traveled throughout the United States taking photographs with the support of two Guggenheim Fellowship grants. During his extended road trip, Frank took hundreds of rolls of film, which he later distilled into a tight sequence of 83 images in a book he called *The Americans*. Frank, who became friends with Walker Evans in the early 1950s, patterned the layout of his book on the older photographer's book *American Photographs*, placing a single photograph on the right side of a given spread. But Frank's elliptical, off-kilter style—encouraged by the immediacy of his 35mm handheld camera—was a distinct counterpoint to Evans's studied approach. This difference was underscored by the Beat writer Jack Kerouac's irreverent introduction to the book, in which he stated (with a wink): "Anybody doesnt like these pitchers don't like potry, see? Anybody dont like potry, go home see Television shots of big hatted cowboys being tolerated by kind horses."

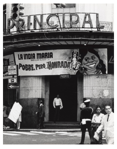
The Americans was met with considerable controversy in part because of Frank's indifference to the traditional markers of "good" photography (sharp focus, pictorial balance, fine grain), but even more because it suggested that the postwar American dream was an illusion, and that the cracks in the facade were evident, even to a recent Swiss émigré. His skeptical, penetrating perspective is exemplified in *Trolley—New Orleans*, which traces the story of segregation through a suite of portraits captured through the windows of a passing bus. Taken only weeks before Rosa Parks refused to give up her seat on a bus in Montgomery, Alabama, the photograph became the cover of the book's first American edition, offering a visual shorthand for the injustice of segregated America during the Eisenhower era.

Barbara Brändli



Barbara Brändli. *Untitled* from the series Sistema nervioso (Nervous System). 1974–75. Gelatin silver print, 10 × 7 15/16" (25.4 × 20.2 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Acquired through the generosity of Ruth Nordenbrook. © 2020 Barbara Brändli

During the 1970s, Venezuela experienced significant economic growth due to increased oil exports. Hailed as a beacon of democracy in Latin America, Venezuela's wealth attracted migrants who flooded the capital city with hopes of a better life. Amidst these changing circumstances, Barbara Brändli began her project Sistema nervioso. Brändli documented the urban transformation of Caracas as a way of "showing the chaos, the improvisation, the humor, the grotesqueness, and the graphic [nature of the city]." Here, the unkempt exterior of a building is graffitied with the expression "YO QUIERO SER," or "I WANT TO BE."



Barbara Brändli. *Untitled* from the series Sistema nervioso (Nervous System). 1974–75. Gelatin silver print, 10 × 6 7/8" (25.4 × 17.5 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Acquired through the generosity of Ramiro Ortiz Mayorga in honor of Patricia Phelps de Cisneros and Gustavo Cisneros through the Latin American and Caribbean Fund. © 2020 Barbara Brändli

In this photograph, the landmark Principal Theater is adorned by an illustration of "La India Maria," a fictional character played by Maria Elena Velasco. Despite the popularity of Velasco's role, the character is rooted in negative stereotypes about indigenous people, depicting them as uneducated, naive, and ill-equipped for "modern life." This idea is reinforced by the banner's caption, which reads, "Poor, but…honorable!"

After seeing Brändli's photographs, designer John Lange proposed they collaborate on a publication about the series. The resulting photo book combines Brändli's black and white photographs with lushly colored pages featuring aphoristic texts by filmmaker and playwright Román Chalbaud. This image of La India Maria is paired with a sentence that states: "sube sobre tu hombro, el peso de la civilización," or "lift up onto your shoulder, the weight of civilization." Together, Chalbaud's writing and Lange's editorial choices magnify the meaning of Brändli's photograph, underscoring the burden of urbanization on the citizens of Caracas.

Mark as completed

Like Dislike Report an issue

Go to next item →